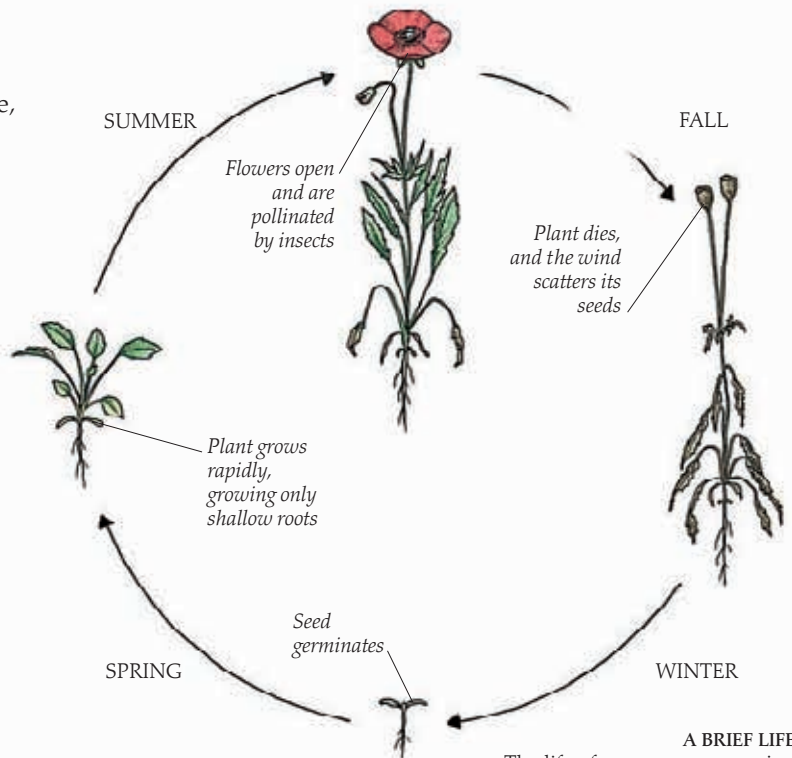


The life cycles of plants

Flowering plants have very different lifespans, ranging from months to centuries. A common poppy will germinate, flower, set seed, and die, all within a single year. Plants that live in this way are known as annuals. Other plants, such as the wild carrot (p. 55), take two years to complete the same process. They flower only in their second year—the first is spent growing and building up food reserves, which they store in a thick, fleshy root. These plants are known as biennials. Perennial plants are those that live for a number of years. They include species such as the dandelion (pp. 30–31). Perennial weeds are a particular problem for gardeners because their long lifespan gives them time to grow very wide-spreading roots.



A BRIEF LIFE

The life of a common poppy is a headlong rush to produce seeds. The seeds from the previous year germinate early in the spring. The young plant grows rapidly, producing only shallow roots. Flower buds appear in early summer, and by midsummer the flowers are open, ready to be pollinated by insects. As soon as they have been pollinated, the flowers wither, and seeds are produced in a pod. The plant dies in the fall, and its seeds are shaken out by the wind. And so the cycle begins again.



FADING FAST

Each nasturtium flower lasts for a number of days, receiving dozens of insect visitors searching for nectar. After the flower has been pollinated, the petals' work is over. The cells begin to lose water, making them shrivel up. The flower may look as if it is dying, but the parts that remain are very much alive.



Developing fruit

GOING TO SEED

After the petals and sepals have fallen away, each flower produces three seeds inside a fruit (p. 31). Like all parts of the nasturtium plant, the seeds and the flesh that surrounds them are rich in a bitter-tasting oil. The fruits are sometimes picked when they are still green, for use in cooking.



Young fruit

Maturing fruit